Predictive Forecasting of Care Load & Placement Demand

Executive Summary for HHS Program Stakeholders

October 15, 2026

What This Tells You

This analysis turns three years of daily UAC Program data into forward-looking forecasts, so that staffing, shelter capacity, and caseworker planning can happen **before** pressure builds, not after. Two things are forecast: (1) how many children will be in HHS care over the next 1–14 days, and (2) how many children will be discharged (placed with sponsors) each day over the same period.

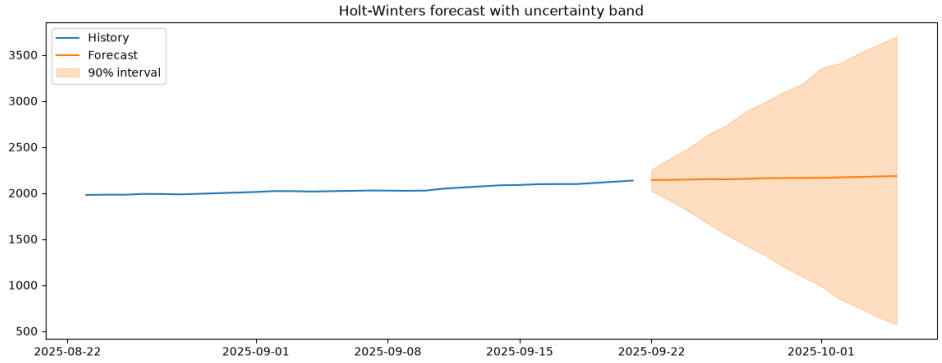
Bottom Line

- Since early 2025, the program has operated in a substantially calmer, more predictable state than in 2023–2024: daily care-load levels have stayed in a narrow, low band, and day-to-day swings are small.
- Our best forecasting model is accurate to within about **0.5% of actual values one week out**, and within about **0.8% two weeks out**.
- Current forecasts show **no near-term risk** of exceeding a defined capacity threshold, with only a small (under 5%) chance of a breach even two weeks ahead.
- Forecasts become noticeably less certain beyond about one week – treat anything past 7 days as a directional signal, not a precise number.

Key Numbers at a Glance

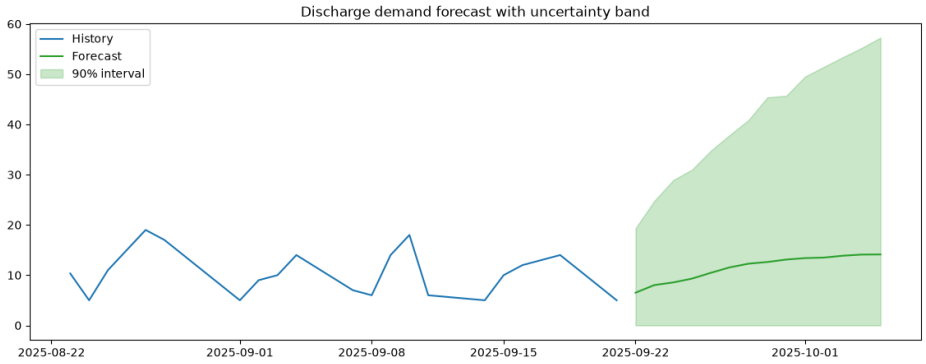
Metric	What It Means
Forecast accuracy (7-day): **99.5%**	How close the model's 7-day-ahead forecasts are to what actually happened.
Capacity breach risk (14-day): **under 5%**	Chance that care load exceeds a planning threshold within two weeks, given current conditions.
Forecast uncertainty growth: **roughly 13× wider by day 14**	How much less certain the forecast becomes the further out it looks – a reminder to re-forecast often rather than relying on one long-range number.
Discharge rate forecast (14-day): **stabilizes around 14/day**	Expected daily placements, consistent with the recent historical average.

Care Load Forecast



The shaded band shows the range of likely outcomes. It is narrow in the near term and widens the further out the forecast looks – this is expected and should guide how far ahead decisions are made with confidence.

Discharge Demand Forecast



Daily discharge (placement) counts are forecast to remain in a steady, low-volatility range consistent with recent operations.

What To Watch

1. **Capacity breach probability.** If this figure begins climbing at the 7- or 14-day horizon, that is the earliest actionable signal to begin scaling shelters and staff – well before any actual breach occurs.

2. **A sudden jump in daily care-load or intake numbers.** The current forecasts assume conditions remain similar to the stable period observed since early 2025. A sharp, sustained change in intake or custody numbers should prompt an immediate model refresh rather than waiting for the next scheduled update.

3. **The 7-day horizon as the planning boundary.** Forecasts are highly reliable through about one week; beyond that, treat the numbers as a general trend rather than a committed figure.

What This Does Not Tell You

This forecast reflects a period that has been unusually calm and stable. It is not a guarantee that conditions will remain this way, and it is not a substitute for monitoring real-time intake data. Its value is in giving planners several days to two weeks of advance notice *if* conditions begin to shift – not in predicting the shift itself before any data exists.

Full technical methodology, limitations, and model comparisons are available in the accompanying research paper. Live dashboard: https://unified-uac-project.streamlit.app/